Lesson 31 material: Narrative Paragraphs 2: Descriptive Details, Model Paragraphs and Writing

Unit 5 Narrative Paragraphs (part VI-VIII)

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Original page, with audio and online exercises: https://harpercollege.pressbooks.pub/academic-writing-skills/chapter/unit-5narrative-paragraphs/
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

VI. Descriptive Vocabulary and Details in Narration

Words are your tools in writing. Choosing **specific, descriptive words** will help your readers "see" or "picture" the event you are describing. Read the pairs of sentences below and discuss which sentence is better in each pair.

- They have a large house.
- They have a 2-story, red brick house.
- An old man walked on the street.
- An eighty-seven-year-old man stumbled[16] along Algonquin Road.
- Mrs. Kim is the best teacher I have ever had.
- Mrs. Kim is the most humorous and hardworking teacher I have ever had.

In each pair, the second sentence helps the reader "see" the house, the man, and Mrs. Kim more vividly[17]. Using descriptive words will make your writing more interesting and effective.

Words like "big, good, nice, great, bad" are very general and can be replaced by other better, more interesting ones. Many of the words below are "sensory" words that describe sight, sound, smell, flavor, and feeling.

General Vocabulary	Descriptive Vocabulary
Afraid	fearful, frightened, petrified, scared, terrified ...
Ask/Say/Tell	beg, command, instruct, murmur, order, plead, whisper, wonder ...
Bad	damaging, detrimental, disadvantageous, harmful, negative ...
Big	bulky, colossal, enormous, gigantic, huge, immense, massive, vast...
Delicious	appetizing, flavorful, rich, mouth-watering, savory, scrumptious, succulent ...
Happy	cheerful, content, delighted, ecstatic, elated, exhilarated, joyful ...
Important	critical, crucial, essential, life-changing, momentous, significant, vital, weighty ...
Look	gaze, glance, glare, glimpse, inspect, marvel, peep, stare ...
Nervous	anxious, concerned, fretful, uneasy, unsettled, worried ...
Walk	hop, ramble, scamper, scuttle, stride, stroll, strut, stumble, tiptoe ...

Before you use any new vocabulary, make sure you check an English-English dictionary to see its exact meaning and use it only when appropriate. Try using two or three new descriptive words in each paragraph you write.

Details are the key to interesting paragraphs. In a narrative paragraph, details in the middle of the narration – how the story progresses – are even more critical[18].

As you learned in the earlier units, color-coding is a helpful strategy to make sure:

- The paragraph has all the essential parts.
- All the parts are in the right order.
- Some parts need to be longer and more detailed.

Here is the color-coded paragraph "The Worst Trip" you read in the beginning of this unit. Discuss:

1. Which color covers the most information?
2. How does the part in blue help you "see" or "experience" what the writer was going through?
3. Underline some descriptive or specific vocabulary . In what way does it make the paragraph more interesting?

My Worst Trip

My experiences at Miami Airport and during the flight to Chicago on September 29, 2007 were terrible because I could not understand English. I came from Mexico, and that was my first connecting trip out of my own country. After a long flight from my native country, I arrived at Miami Airport. I had been so excited walking in an American airport until a uniformed officer asked me something in English. I felt nervous because I did not speak English and did not know how to answer her questions. I just shook my head. I was not walking excitedly anymore because I realized that I did not speak the language. I already began to miss my own country! Suddenly, I looked at my watch, and it said 12:30 pm. I was so hungry that I needed to eat something. I had not eaten much on my first flight. I went to a small restaurant in the airport, looked at the pictures of the menu on the screen, and decided to have a coke and a sandwich. I could not see clearly or read what kind of sandwich that was, but it looked scrumptious. I was just going to point to the picture and

tell the waiter what I wanted. He came and spoke fast. Because I did not understand, I felt I had to say "Ok". Well, he gave me a different meal, and it cost me almost $20! This situation was awful. I ate the meal in sad silence. I could not tell what it tasted like because I was tired and upset. Finally, I got on my flight to Chicago in the evening. On the plane, I wanted to drink water, but I did not know how to ask for it. I just stayed in my seat quietly and felt despondent. In the end, I met my family at the airport in Chicago at 11:30 pm. On our way home, I told them about my nightmare. They comforted me, "Don't worry. All will be fine." However, I could not shake off the feeling that I had just had a rocky start on my life in this new country. On that day, I made a promise to myself that I would have to study English really hard.

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Exercise 5. Try to write a new sentence with descriptive vocabulary by replacing the words underlined.

Example:

The family carried the big mattress into the small apartment.

Improved: The family carried the bulky mattress into the one-bedroom apartment.

(Picture: a cruise ship)

a cruise ship

1. The big cruise ship has 18 decks and is 1188 feet long.
2. My upcoming interview is going to be important to my career.
3. The family made a big decision to immigrant to the U.S. one year ago.
4. The mother walked into the baby's room quietly.
5. The graduates walked proudly onto the stage to receive their diploma.
6. Some parents have a bad influence on their children.
7. In darkness, I was very afraid when I heard a strange noise behind me.
8. I love looking at the stars in the night sky.
9. The mom said no, but the boy still asked for more ice cream.
10. The students are nervous about their grades.

Exercise 6. Use Paragraph "My Worst Trip" you just discussed as an example. Color code Paragraph "My Memorable Interview" as follows and discuss the questions below.

1. Color code the paragraph:

Title – ***pink*** Background information – ***purple***

Topic sentence – ***red*** Beginning of the story – ***green***

Middle of the story – ***blue*** End of the story – ***green***

Transitions – ***yellow*** Concluding sentence(s) – ***red***

2. Discuss:

- Which color covers the most information?
- How does the part in blue help you "see" or "experience" what the writer was going through?
- Underline the descriptive or specific vocabulary. In what way does it make the paragraph more interesting?

VII. More Narrative Paragraph Examples

As you read more narrative paragraphs below, you may color code them as you have done for the earlier paragraphs.

Discuss:

1. How does the writer start the paragraph? How many sentences does the writer have for the topic sentence and background information? What is the controlling idea?
2. Does the background information include what, who, when, and where?
3. Are the events arranged in chronological order?
4. What different types of time transitions are used?
5. Does all the information in the story support the main idea?
6. Is the middle of the story the longest in the paragraph?
7. Underline some specific descriptions. How do they help make the story more interesting?
8. Does the writer use past tenses to narrate the story? Are present and future tenses used? If so, why is the past tense changed to a present or future one?
9. What do you like about the paragraph? How would you like to improve it?
10. If you could ask the writer one question, what question would it be?

EXERCISE

#1 My First Conversation Class (by K. Florek): My First Conversation Class My conversation class on August 22, 2022 at Harper College was very exciting. It was my first class at the college and in the United States. I was very happy because I wanted to speak better English and meet other people. Everything was new to me, a new school and a new environment, but I wasn't feeling stressed out. When the class started at 9 am, our teacher Sarah introduced herself first in a friendly smile. There were more than 10 students from different countries. The teacher and the students all looked good, and their stories were very interesting. Everyone listened carefully and had a chance to speak. The teacher gave suggestions and commented on each introduction

positively. She helped us understand each other in English. I realized that everyone needed guidance. Twenty minutes later, we started to learn more about the class, for example, the textbook and the Blackboard. It was nice to see how the Blackboard provided useful information such as practice materials and grades. After learning about the class, we began the first chapter of our textbook. It was about how to greet people, and it was easy for me. We then played an entertaining game. One person sat on a chair with his/her back to the white board. The teacher wrote a word on the board, and the rest of the class had to talk about it so that the sitting student was able to guess what the word was. We had a great time, lots of laughs. Towards the end of the lesson, the teacher gave us an interesting vocabulary quiz. It was supposed to show what level of English we were at. It went really well for me, and I was glad that my level was a little better than I had imagined. Finally, the teacher gave us homework, some tasks from the textbook and a video about her favorite book. I felt amazed on this first day of class. I knew that I was meeting great people and that my conversation skills would improve dramatically. Going to school and enrolling in this class made me feel more hopeful for the new life I had just started in the United States. By K. Florek (student), ESL Writing III, Harper College. Us ed with permission.

#2 My Most Angry Experience (by E. Elmasllari): My Most Angry Experience My most angry experience occurred on my trip from Istanbul in Turkey to Chicago. On July 2, 2020, my husband, our two daughters, and I arrived at airport in Istanbul two hours before take-off, according to the flight recommendation. As soon as we checked our luggage, we received our seat assignments. We would be sitting in three different areas of the plane although we had booked our tickets four months before and arranged to be sitting together. My daughters, age 9 and 14, would not be sitting with either parent. This angered us immensely. It was not a good idea for two young girls to sit among strangers on their first long fight abroad. We talked with the airport staff, but they did not accommodate us, saying that the flight was full. My husband then pleaded with a few more staff members but to no avail. To our dismay, we found out after boarding that the same situation was happening to many other parents. Many children, some crying, were seated apart from their parents. There was a real chaos on the plane as the parents were protesting and refusing to sit away from their children. Our daughters were nervous, and the younger one started to cry. After a few minutes, we managed to switch seats with some parents and were finally able to sit with our children, and the other parents with theirs. Things began to quiet down as most travelers, young or not, settled in their seats. Even though the flight was relatively comfortable afterwards, the incident set an unpleasant tone in our minds for the remainder of the trip. By E. Elmasllari (student), ESL Writing III, Harper College. Us ed with permission.

#3 A Dangerous Night in La Cross, Wisconsin (by W. Yan): A Dangerous Night in La Cross, Wisconsin Three years ago, I had the most terrifying experience of my life on the night before I started a waitressing job at a Japanese restaurant in La Cross, Wisconsin. The restaurant was far from Chicago. That afternoon, I took the train to La Cross by myself. Five hours later, it was 8:00 pm and snowing outside when I arrived. A man almost forty years old picked me up. He was a restaurant worker, too. While he was driving, I asked him questions about the restaurant, but he did not talk too much. He drove half an hour to a house. I followed him quietly with my luggage. I was shocked when I walked into the house. This place was like a ghost house. How could people live in such a horrible place? The house was dirty, dark, and old. I could not imagine when they swept the floor the last time. The kitchen was messy, too. The table was covered with the snack bags and cigarettes. I saw a mouse running across the room when the man opened another door. Even worse, he told me that the tiny room was mine. I looked around: One bed was in the middle, a blanket was on the bed, and two white candles were on a dirty table. All looked so weird. I never liked candles because they looked creepy to me. Maybe I had watched too many horror movies. The windows were broken. Someone had used old clothes and paper to cover the broken parts. The light was very dark. Before the man left my room, he told me that my door could not lock. I wondered what had happened, but he said it was a long story. Just in case, I texted the address to my friend and prayed to God that I would not be murdered in the middle of the night. I lay on the bed with my clothes on and my eyes wide open. Time passed very slowly that dangerous night. It was unbelievable that I ended up working in that restaurant for five months! Thankfully, the coworkers were very nice to me after the first night. Now, when I remember that night in La Cross, I still feel creepy. By W . Yan (student), ESL Writing III, Harper College. U sed with permission.

#4 A Valuable Approach (by R. Oad): A Valuable Approach I learned an important approach in dealing with nervousness on my trip to Ayubia for the first time on August 3rd, 2019. Ayubia had pretty mountains, tall trees, and colorful shops of accessories. I was so excited to go. At 9:00 am that day, my cousin and uncle persuaded me to go on the chair lift that would take us to the peak of the mountain. I sat with my cousin Priya. We both were scared of the height and were extremely frightened. As the chair lifted, Priya and I started screaming. On the way up, we panicked and kept our eyes tightly shut. Suddenly, we heard a boy singing. We opened our eyes and found this boy just as attractive as his voice. He was just beside us in the lift. We started singing with him, and that time we realized Ayubia had such great beauty of green mountains and luscious trees. Some people in the chair lift were laughing at us, but we enjoyed ourselves and continued singing along. Surprisingly, the songs distracted our minds. We happily reached the peak of the mountain and had a great time. From all this, I learned a valuable lesson that everything was just in our mind. Every fear is temporary. If we are always fearful, we will never enjoy anything in our life. On that day, I decided that I would start singing a song whenever I became scared. I have done it so many times since and will continue this approach whenever necessary. By R. Oad (student), ESL Writing III, Harper College. U sed with permission.

#5 A Lesson about Curiosity (by S. Voloshyn): A Lesson about Curiosity The day when my parents gave me my first phone was very exciting for me, but I didn't expect that there was an important lesson in store for me. It was in 2000, and I was an 11-year-old girl who was studying in a middle school in Ukraine. At that time, most kids did not have their own phone because it was just the beginning of the technical era. My first phone was a grey Panasonic with a large antenna. It was huge and often did not fit into my pocket. I had to buy a separate bag for it. For me, the phone was amazing. It had big buttons that shone in different colors and sounded like some songs. It also had a screen that showed colorful pictures. Later, when I learned what all the buttons were for and what this phone could do, I was interested in knowing how everything worked. I found my dad's tools, took a screwdriver, and opened the back cover of the phone. Inside there were a lot of small green parts with iron wires. I was shocked to see how neat everything was in there and how many pieces there were. Inside I found a little interesting-looking ball and pulled it out. Then I closed the back cover of the phone, put back my dad's tools, and went to play with that bright ball. The next day, I took the phone and tried to turn it on, but it did not work. I was terrified. I started crying and screaming. Right away came my grandfather. He asked me what had happened, and I answered that I could not turn on my phone. He then asked me if I had done something with it, but I lied and said no. At that moment, I was really scared and nervous because the phone was expensive. My family would be very angry with what I had done. However, honesty was the best policy. Moments later, I confessed my guilt and stood in the corner, ready to accept the punishment. I had to stand still for two hours. From that experience, I understood an important lesson about curiosity: Never look at what a phone looks like inside. My Panasonic lay in my closet for many years as a reminder about what had happened. I have not "destroyed" anything out of curiosity since then. By S. Voloshyn (student), ESL Writing III, Harper College. Used with permission.

#6 My Most Relaxing Morning: My Most Relaxing Morning Last Tuesday morning was my most relaxing time of the week. After taking classes and working from Wednesday through the following Monday, it was nice to be able to sleep in without using my alarm clock. When I opened my eyes, it was already after 10 am. The apartment was quiet as my neighbors were working. The sun was gently shining on my bed through the translucent curtain. I lazily stretched myself in bed till I was fully awake. In my pajamas and slippers, I spent the next half an hour tidying up my bedroom and living room. At 11 am, with soft music playing, I started preparing my brunch. Since I had been studying and working hard all week, I decided to treat myself: a glass of freshly squeezed orange juice, half a cup of mixed nuts, and a plate of home-made omelet filled with vegetables, cheese, and some shreds of leftover roasted chicken breast. I took time to eat and savor each bite. Life was good! When my leisurely brunch ended, I had recovered from the week's fatigue. I was ready for new challenges in the afternoon.

Exercise 7. Read the following two paragraphs. You may color code them as you have done for the earlier paragraphs. Discuss the following questions in your group.

1. What is the topic sentence? Is there a controlling idea in the topic sentence? If not, write one.
2. Does the background information include what, who, when, and where? If something is missing, add it.
3. Are the events arranged in chronological order? If not, correct the order.
4. Does all the information in the story support the main idea? If anything is irrelevant, cross it out.
5. Are the transitions used appropriately? If a transition is wrong, correct it. If a transition is missing, add it.
6. Are there enough descriptive details in the middle of the story? What more ideas can you add?
7. Does the writer use correct past tenses to narrate the story?
8. Are there any present and future tenses? If so, why is there a shift in verb tenses?
9. What do you like about the paragraph?
10. If you could ask the writer one question, would question would you ask?

EXERCISE

#1 My Parking Lot Nightmare: My Parking Lot Nightmare It was in the early afternoon of January 21, 2015. After two classes at Harper College, I went to the parking lot, but I cannot find my car. I was thinking and thinking about my parking spot four hours before, but my memory was just telling me "Building J". I walked around and around Parking Lot 4 but still could not find my car. I do not know what to do. Maybe I walked back and forth ten times that day. While I was walking, I thought about many bad scenarios. Thirty minutes passed, and I finally found my car in Parking Lot 6! I was so relieved! I was so happy to see my car. My backpack was very heavy. I had to carry it while looking for my car. I learned my lesson. I always check the parking lot number twice and try to park in the same lot. I have not had a problem locating my car in the lot in the past 2 years.

#2 My Busy Holiday: My Busy Holiday Thanksgiving Day in 2018 was a busy day for me because many relatives came to my house for dinner. Two days before, I had bought a big turkey, marinated it, and kept it in my cold garage. At 4 pm on Thanksgiving Day, my relatives arrived. We hug each other and say "Happy Thanksgiving". The children began to play video games in the family room while the adults chatted and ate snacks in the living room. My cousin helped me in the kitchen. Together we prepared twenty dishes: roasted turkey, mashed potatoes with gravy, cranberry jelly, pumpkin pie, and many others. We started dinner. Everyone enjoyed the food. After dinner, the children continue their games, and the adults all gathered around the fireplace and were talking about family, job, and hobbies. At midnight, some relatives left for home, and some went to the mall for Black Friday shopping. Black Friday is a good time to get deals, and once I even bought a 48-inch TV for less than $500. After all the guests left, I feel exhausted and go to sleep. It was a happy but tiring day for me.

VIII. Unit Review Practice: Writing Assignments

Now you are ready to write your own narrative paragraph! As you have learned in Unit 2 The Writing Process, (*Open Unit 2 here.*) the best way to plan a paragraph is to follow the proper steps.

Narrative Paragraph Writing Assignments

You will be writing two at-home narrative paragraphs. The second one will start after the first one is complete. For both assignments, follow the instructions below.

Purpose: To show your understanding of planning and writing a narrative paragraph. Use the writing process to help you.

Topic: Choose from the list below.

Brainstorm and Outline: Brainstorm for ideas. Then use one of the templates below to make an outline. Your outline is due on _____. Bring it to class.

Paragraph: Your paragraph should have a title, a topic sentence, background information, beginning of the story, middle of the story with details, the end of the story, a conclusion, and appropriate time transitions. Include at least 5 descriptive vocabulary from Section VI in this unit (Descriptive Vocabulary and Details in Narration).

Format: Type your paragraph, double spaced, font size 12, with 1-inch margins on four sides of the page. Type your name, class, and date on the upper right-hand corner of the page. The first line of your paragraph should be indented. Save your paragraph in a Word file.

Self Checklist: When you finish writing, use the Self Checklist below. Put a checkmark beside each item if you think you did a good job in that area. Otherwise, improve your paragraph until you can check off the item. Save your work again.

Submission: Submit your paragraph on the Blackboard. Go to your Blackboard course site and follow the instructions there. Due by _____.

Choose one of the following topics. If you wish to write about a topic of your own, discuss with your professor first.

1. Your first class (reading, writing, grammar, communication skills, or another class) experience at Harper College
2. A time when you helped someone in need
3. Your proudest moment

4. Your most embarrassing experience
5. A disappointing shopping trip
6. An experience where you got to know yourself better
7. An experience where you got to know another person better
8. An experience that changed your opinion of an event
9. An interview you had (any kind of interview)
10. The day when you got your first cell phone

Narrative Paragraph Outline Template #1

Topic: _____

Controlling idea: _____

Background information:

What: _____

When: _____

Where: _____

Who: _____

Topic + controlling idea + background information (1 – 3 complete sentences):

_____

(Picture: a narrative timeline)

a narrative timeline

Narrative Paragraph Outline Template #2

Topic: _____

Controlling idea: _____

Background information:

What: _____

When: _____

Where: _____

Who: _____

Topic + controlling idea + background information (1 – 3 complete sentences):

_____

Beginning of the story:

Middle of the story:

End of the story:

Narrative Paragraph Self Checklist

Questions	**Paragraph Revising and Editing Self Checklist**	√
1	Is my paragraph on topic and clear to understand?	
2	Did I include a topic sentence with a clear controlling idea?	
3	Did I include background information on what, who, when, and where in the beginning?	
4	Did I include interesting, descriptive details that support the main idea?	
5	Did I have a beginning, a middle (the longest), and an ending?	
6	Did I narrate the story in chronological order? Did I use proper time expressions?	
7	Did all my verbs agree with their subjects (subject-verb agreement)? Did I use proper past tenses and other tenses?	
8	Did I try my best to use correct sentence structure (simple, compound, complex)?	
9	Did I try my best to use correct grammar such as nouns, pronouns, word form, word order, and others?	
10	Did I try my best to have correct spelling, punctuation, and capitalization?	
11	Did I follow the proper paragraph format?	
12	Did I include at least 5 vocabulary words from Section VI?	

Note: #7 – #10 may include more specific aspects of grammar depending on how many editing units you have already studied.

NSNT Practice

(Picture: a pen writing in a notebook)

a pen writing in a notebook

Go to **The NSNT Free Writing Approach and Additional Weekly Prompts for Writing** in Appendix A. *(Open Appendix A here.)* Choose two topics to write a paragraph each. You may start with the NSNT approach and then revise and edit the paragraphs using the Self Checklist above. You are encouraged to share your writing with your partner and help each other improve.

EXERCISE

Writing task: You may write in your notebook or in the box below. (Warning: Once you leave this page, you will lose what you have written in the box.) .

Vocabulary Review

(Picture: a page in a dictionary)

a page in a dictionary

The words here have appeared in this unit. The best way to learn them is to guess the meaning of each word from the context. Then hover your computer mouse over the number beside each word to check its meaning and part of speech. These words are also listed in the footnote area at the end of each unit.

Here, you can use the flashcards below to review these words.

EXERCISE

- **scrumptious**: adjective, delicious
- **awful**: adjective, terrible
- **despondent**: adjective, feeling sad and hopeless
- **a rocky start**: noun phrase, not a smooth beginning
- **exhausting**: adjective, very tiring
- **Misfortune goes hand in hand.**: a saying, Bad things happen one after another.
- **superficially**: adverb, on the surface, not deeply
- **elaborately**: adverb, with great care and effort
- **approach**: verb, handle, deal with
- **irresponsibly**: adverb, not responsibly, carelessly
- **assume**: verb, guess or think based on what has happened
- **diligence**: noun, good efforts
- **attentive**: adjective, giving careful attention
- **genie**: noun, a spirit that makes wishes come true for people
- **transform**: verb, change in significant ways
- **stumble**: verb, walk unsteadily, as if going to fall
- **vividly**: adverb, lively and brightly
- **critical**: adjective, extremely important

Summary

1. A narrative paragraph focuses on describing an event, an experience, or a story.
2. A narrative paragraph should have a title, a beginning with a topic sentence and background information, a middle with details, and an ending.
3. Descriptive vocabulary and details will make the paragraph interesting.
4. The story should be narrated in the chronological order and should use proper time transitions.
5. Past tenses are used primarily, but other tenses are often needed, too.
6. Following the writing process (pre-writing, writing, and post-writing) can ensure a well- organized and well-supported paragraph.

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1. scrumptious: adjective, delicious ↵
2. awful: adjective, terrible ↵
3. despondent: adjective, feeling sad and hopeless ↵
4. a rocky start: noun phrase, not a smooth beginning ↵

5. exhausting: adjective, very tiring ↲
6. Misfortune goes hand in hand: a saying, bad things happen one after another. ↲
7. superficially: adverb, on the surface, not deeply ↲
8. elaborately: adverb, with great care and effort ↲
9. approach: verb, handle, deal with ↲
10. irresponsibly: adverb, not responsibly, carelessly ↲
11. assume: verb, guess or think based on what has happened ↲
12. diligence: noun, good efforts ↲
13. attentive: adjective, giving careful attention ↲
14. genie: noun, a spirit that makes wishes come true for people ↲
15. transform: verb, change in significant ways ↲
16. stumble: verb, walk unsteadily, as if going to fall ↲
17. vividly: adverb, lively and brightly ↲
18. critical: adjective, extremely important ↲